



# Orthodoxy 301

On Frequency of Holy Communion

## Christ Amongst Us

**Blessed is the Kingdom...**  
BLESSING IS THE THEOPHANY

The Divine Liturgy is the Kingdom of God. It is at this moment that Christ allows us to enter and see His Kingdom. What a great honor this is, and how very observant we should be at this time!

**Wisdom. Arise!**

"Wisdom! Arise!" It is as if the Priest is telling us: "Christ and His Gospel are the true wisdom. Let us be attentive."

**Holy God, Holy Mighty, Holy Immortal, have mercy on us.**  
THE THEOPHANY HYMN

...One time for the Father, who is Holy, Mighty, and Immortal; one time for the Son who is Holy, Mighty, and Immortal; and one time for the Holy Spirit who is Holy, Mighty, and Immortal...

**Wisdom. Arise! Let us hear the Holy Gospel.**

So let us stand silently and calmly—for we are not going to hear a message read from some earthly king, but from the King of the angels!

**...that we may receive the King of all...**  
THE GREAT ENTRANCE

Upon hearing the Cherubic Hymn, the faithful prepare for the Great Entrance—they ready themselves to welcome the King of Glory who is now entering the Holy City to be crucified for all of us, escorted by the angelic orders.

**I believe in one God...**

...The faithful, confess their faith in the Holy Trinity—in order to rightly commune of the Bread of Life, a person must have love and confess the true faith.

**Let us stand well; let us stand with fear; let us attend, that we may offer the holy oblation in peace.**

...carefully consider what is happening: how the Lamb of God is coming to be sacrificed for us; how the precious Blood of the Lord is ready to be poured out into the holy Chalice...

**Take, eat, this is my Body which is broken for you for the forgiveness of sins. Drink of it all of you; this is my Blood of the new Covenant which is shed for you and for many for the forgiveness of sins.**

...the most dread and wondrous mystery of the whole Liturgy is taking place inside the holy Sanctuary. The Bread and the Wine, which up until this moment merely represented the Lord's Body and the Blood, are now truly transformed into His real Body and Blood.

**Especially for our most holy, pure, blessed... Lady...**

...The Church thanks God for the Patriarchs, Prophets, and Apostles... But, above all, she remembers the All-holy Theotokos... Because the Church knows her to be the bridge which transports mankind from the Earth to the Heavens.

**We hymn You, we bless You, we give thanks unto You, O Lord...**

...the words of consecration resounds from the holy Sanctuary—as if they had been pronounced by Christ Himself! They are the very same words with which the Lord addressed His disciples at the Mystical Supper...

**Our Father Who art in Heaven...**

...be amazed at the unfathomable wealth of God's great benevolence towards us! You were ordered to call Him Father—you who are earthly and He Who is of the Heavens, you who are mortal and He Who is immortal, you who are perishable and He Who is imperishable.

**With the fear of God, with faith and love, draw near...**

The faithful approach the Holy Chalice with faith. The believer is convinced that he will be granted even more strength than those who touched the fringe of His garments and were healed!

This poster accompanies the book *Christ Amongst Us: An Easy to Understand Commentary on the Divine Liturgy According to the Writings of the Holy Fathers and the*  
*Exposition of the Same* by George Dinshaw and Christina Maitland-Dinshaw. © Copyright 1997, Newcome Press, LLC.



# ONE IS HOLY, ONE IS LORD

- ♦ Is the response of the choir/chanters. This is because none of us are Holy, Only the ONE WHO IS!
- ♦ In a custom that is no longer done in churches at least here today, a curtain would have been closed - this is usually done though during Great Lent in the Presanctified Liturgy.
- ♦ From St. John Chrysostom *“These words function as a warning period you cannot say, ‘I didn’t know, I was unaware that there was any danger’... So that you might not attempt to use this excuse, the priest raises his hand high and exclaims this in a loud voice - as the kind of a town crier - summoning some to Holy Communion, while prohibiting others...”*
- ♦ Considering the same phrase, St. Nicholas Cabasilas *“Not everyone is permitted to partake of the spotless mysteries... Because the Holy Things ought to be given only to the holy people. The word holy means all those who are perfect in terms of virtue, as well as those who struggle to reach that kind of perfection... Because nothing prevents them from being sanctified by partaking of the holy mysteries.”*
- ♦ Our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ established the celebration of The Divine Liturgy for this unique purpose: that we may be united with Him by partaking of His Holy Body and His all-spotless Blood. Holy Communion is that very moment when this special purpose is realized!



# Frequent Communion

## *Personal preparedness*

The decline in frequent Communion came about gradually. Following the peace of Constantine, the awesome sacredness of Communion was increasingly emphasized over and against the personal worthiness of the communicant, a concept that found its way into liturgical texts: "It [Communion] is a burning observance of the Eucharistic fast (to eat nothing from the last meal of the day to the time of Communion), additional external ascetical expressions of piety were also promoted as essential for participation in the sacrament. These included strict fast rules, abstinence from sexual intercourse, compulsory confession, and other devotional acts. Some have suggested that the strong emphasis on personal worthiness deterred many, fearful of condemnation, from receiving frequently. The strict fast rules led many to connect Communion with the great fast periods of the year (Great Lent/Holy Week, the fast of the Apostles, the Dormition fast, and the fast of Christmas which slowly expanded to forty days). Thus was born the idea that Communion should be received four times or less a year.

Happily, in our days, thanks to the reemergence of devotional piety centered on the Eucharist, many families have espoused the practice of frequent Communion.

Of course, the challenge before every communicant is to maintain a deep reverence for and have a clear understanding of what Holy Communion is and means. The reception of Communion should not be reduced to an empty habit, a hollow custom. Adults and even children – in language and imagery proper to their age – should be taught to value Communion as an extraordinary event, an act of faith, and a wondrous gift that is given freely by God and

not something one earns. The basic preparation for Communion is the daily struggle to bring one's will freely into conformity with the divine will and to love in a way that enables us to identify with Christ and with the sufferings of the least among us.

## *Not for adoration but for consumption*

The elevation of the Amnos should not be interpreted as a form of eucharistic adoration. The Orthodox Church does not practice eucharistic adoration, at least not as it is understood and practiced in the Roman Church – as an extra-liturgical devotional practice.<sup>436</sup> The consecrated Holy Gifts are presented and offered not for adoration but for consumption: "Take eat...Drink of this...." Nevertheless, Orthodox Christians know intuitively the awesome, sacred character of the Holy Gifts. In their presence they bow and cross themselves reverently fully aware of their sacred identity – the Body and Blood of Christ.

## *Not a blessing object*

On another note, as already mentioned, the Holy Gifts should never be thought of or used as a blessing "object." The clergy should avoid making the sign of the cross with the Gifts over the people at the Great Entrance or when exhibiting the chalice before and after Communion.

## *Τὰ Ἅγια τοῖς ἁγίοις*

The manual act of elevating the Lamb is accompanied by the words, "Τὰ Ἅγια τοῖς ἁγίοις – *The Holy Gifts for the Holy People of God.*" The exclamation, spoken reverently by the priest as he lifts the Lamb, is both an invitation and a warning.

The exclamation summons the faithful to Communion, to partake of the "holy things – τὰ ἅγια." The "holy things" are none other than the Holy Gifts: the gifts of bread and wine prepared and offered to God by the people in praise of and in thanksgiving for his mighty acts. They are the gifts which God receives and consecrates and are offered back to us for the forgiveness of sins and life eternal.

We offer up human food – the emblems of our humanity – in order to receive the Food of Life, the Body and Blood of the incarnate Son of God (John 6:55-59). In exchange for our fleeting mortal life we receive and partake of the divine life (2 Peter 1:4); we are given the gifts of incorruptibility and immortality. "Then Jesus said to them, Truly, truly, I say to you, unless you eat the flesh of the Son of Man and drink his blood, you have no life in you; he who eats my

<sup>436</sup> Eucharistic adoration is practiced by Roman Catholics, at least since the sixteenth century, in the belief that the consecrated reserved host encased in a monstrance is truly the Body of Christ and therefore of his real presence. Eucharistic adoration is an extra-liturgical devotional practice.



flesh and drinks my blood has eternal life, and I will raise him up at the last day" (John 6:53-54).

The invitation to Communion is simultaneously a warning. The "holy things" are for the "holy ones – τοῖς ἁγίοις." The unworthy are advised to stay away. "Let not everyone come to receive," writes Cabasilas in his *Commentary* (4:36), "but only those who are worthy, for holy things are for the holy only." Or as the plea in one of the private devotional pre-communion prayers says, "let not these Holy Gifts be to my judgment because I am unworthy...."

This cautionary approach to Communion was known and practiced from the start. St. Paul, for example, makes reference to it when he wrote these words to the Corinthians: "Whoever eats the bread and drinks the cup of the Lord in an unworthy manner will be guilty of profaning the body and blood of the Lord.... For anyone who eats and drinks without discerning the body eats and drinks judgment upon himself" (1 Cor. 11:27, 29). And he continued, "Let a man examine himself, and so eat of the bread and drink of the cup" (1 Cor. 11:28). A similar warning is embedded in the anaphora. We read in CHR, "So that [these Holy Gifts] may be for those who partake of them for vigilance of soul...[and] not for judgment or condemnation." Or as it is said in BAS, "Grant that none of us may partake of the holy Body and Blood of your Christ for judgment or condemnation."

*But Who are the Holy Ones, the ἅγιοι, to whom Communion is Given?*<sup>437</sup>

From the earliest days the term *saints* – ἅγιοι, as we know from the Epistles of St. Paul and others, was applied to the faithful, to those set apart by baptism who conscientiously strive to live their lives in accordance with the will of God. Here is how Cabasilas explains it. "Those whom the priest calls holy are not only those who have attained perfection, but those also who are striving for it without having yet obtained it.... The faithful are called saints because of the holy thing of which they partake, because of him whose Body and Blood they receive.... As long as we remain united to him and preserve our connection with him, we live by holiness, drawing to ourselves, through the Holy Mysteries the sanctity which comes from that Head and that Heart. But if we should cut ourselves off, if we should separate ourselves from the unity of this most holy Body, we partake of the Holy Mysteries in vain, for life cannot flow into dead and amputated limbs."<sup>438</sup>

<sup>437</sup> See Taft, *Precommunion Rites*, 234-40.

<sup>438</sup> Cabasilas, *Commentary*, 4:36.

### *Who Then Can Receive Holy Communion?*

Saint Justin the Martyr (ca. 150) gives the following concise response: "This food we call eucharist, and no one may share it unless he believes that our teaching is true, and has been cleansed in the bath of forgiveness for sin and of rebirth, and lives as Christ taught."<sup>439</sup> According to this ancient maxim, to partake of the Holy Mysteries one must be baptized, espouse the faith of the Church, and walk in the newness of life (Rom 6:4). Or, as Cabasilas, puts it: "Christians, if they have not committed [mortal] sins as would cut them off from Christ and bring death, are in no way prevented, when partaking of the Holy Mysteries, from receiving sanctification, not in name alone, but in fact, since they continue to be living members united to the Head."<sup>440</sup>

Cabasilas' words, in part, are based on 1 John 5:16-17. The Apostle, Evangelist and Theologian John distinguishes between two kinds of sin, those which do not lead to death and those which do (mortal sins). The former, even when repugnant, are forgiven. The deadly mortal sins, however, are beyond forgiveness, not because God is incapable of forgiving them, but because the transgressors are in a continual and willful state of denial and disobedience; they deliberately reject the truth, love, and grace of God; they blaspheme against the Holy Spirit (Matt. 12:31-33).

*One is Holy, one is Lord, Jesus Christ...*

The invitation to Communion requires a proper response. Byzantine and ecclesial etiquette demands it. In light of our human weaknesses, frailties, and failings there could be only one, simple, direct, and appropriate response: "One alone is holy." Indeed, as Cabasilas tells it, "No one has holiness of himself. It is not the consequence of human virtue but comes to all from [God] and through him."<sup>441</sup> The response includes a Christological formula which affirms the divinity of Christ: "One is Holy, one is Lord, Jesus Christ, to the glory of God the Father. Amen."<sup>442</sup>

We believe and confess in the Creed that the Church is holy, even though she is not yet perfect. The holiness of the Church, however, is not derived from, nor is it dependent upon, the moral and pious life of its members, but from it being the mystical Body of Christ. The Church is holy because its Lord is holy. The Church is holy because it is the event of truth and the fact of the incarnation of

<sup>439</sup> Justin, *Apologia* 1:65-6. Note Justin's use of the word eucharist. It identifies both the sacred service and the sacramental elements – "this food we call eucharist."

<sup>440</sup> Cabasilas, *Commentary*, 4:36.

<sup>441</sup> Ibid.

the Son of God. Through the Church God calls all human beings to repentance and bestows upon them the gift of sanctification. Until the Final Judgment, the righteous as well as the sinful are included in the Church. Every member of the Church is a work in progress. Everyone, as Metropolitan John Zizioulas tells it, "is a potential saint, even if he appears to have been or continues to be a sinner."<sup>443</sup> Every believing member of the Church, however deficient or feeble their faith and inner life may be, still bears a trace of holiness, however faint. Everyone has the capacity to grow. It is incumbent upon us to reach out in order to help them grow their faith and strengthen their conscience. (Cf. Matt. 13:23; Mark 4:8; John 14:22).

The response, "One is Holy," was added to the pre-communion rites in the fourth century, if not earlier. The Christological formula is based on Phil 2:11, "Jesus Christ is Lord, to the glory of God the Father." The response includes a concluding "Amen" and an opening affirmation, "One is holy" the exact origins of which are unclear, although we meet the title "Holy One of Israel," in the Old Testament.<sup>444</sup>

### *The Communion Hymn – Τὸ Κοινωνικόν – Koinonikon*

Immediately after the call to Communion, the people sing the Koinonikon during which the priest performs several manual acts.

In current practice the Communion hymn is comprised of one or two biblical verses, most often from a psalm, ending with a triple Alleluia.<sup>445</sup> Basically, the Koinonikon covers the manual actions and communion of the clergy and, after the call to communion is announced, the communion of the people. While it serves a utilitarian function in the first instance, the essential purpose of the Koinonikon is to prepare the minds and hearts of the faithful for the reception of the Holy Mysteries. In time, a new type of Koinonikon was also introduced. It was and is sung on major feast days, the aim of which is to connect and associate the reception of Communion to a given feast. This connection, however, is not always evident.

<sup>443</sup> Metropolitan John Zizioulas, "Communion and Otherness," in SVTQ, 38, 4 (1994), 354. Elsewhere, he makes the same point. "The Church depicts the end time in history.... The Church in history is clearly not identical with the kingdom of God. The trauma of history means that along with the rest of the world, Christians struggle with evil, and the way of the cross is this struggle. The Church is not the society of those who have overcome evil but of those who are struggling against evil. The holy Church is full of sinners, being made holy. Therefore, we must say that the kingdom of God is depicted in the Church. This iconological ontology is key." In John D. Zizioulas: *Lectures in Christian Dogmatics*, Douglas H. Knight, ed. (London 2008), 136.

<sup>444</sup> See Taft, *Precommunion Rites*, 246-48. The title "Holy One of Israel," is found in: 2 Kings 19:22; Isaiah 1:4, 10:22, 12:6, and 41:14; Jeremiah 50:29; Psalm 71:22; and Psalm 89:18.

<sup>445</sup> On the joyful, celebratory, and doxological nature of the Alleluia see Fountoulis, *Ἀναμνηστικὴ εἰς λειτουργικὰς Ἀπορίας*, vol. 5 (Athens 2003), 32-42.



# Holy Communion

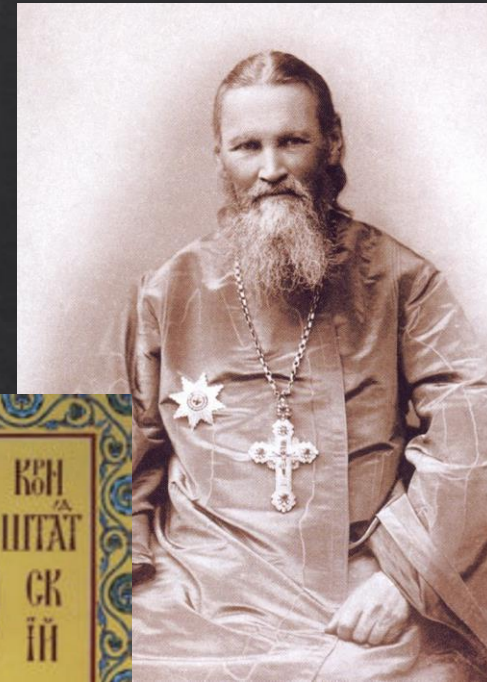
- ◆ Uniting the Holy Body and precious Blood of our Lord and Savior, the Clergy remembers the Resurrection of Christ from the dead. The prayers offered at this delicate and awe-inspiring moment indicate that the Holy Mystery is accomplished through the action of the Holy Spirit. As the Clergy pours the warm water (zeon) into the Holy Chalice, we realize that only by possessing a faith that is kindled by the Grace of the Holy Spirit can we hope to participate faithfully in the Holy Eucharist.
- ◆ The purpose of our attendance and participation in The Divine Liturgy has fully arrived. There is only one purpose for The Divine Liturgy... its purpose is for us to partake of the Holy Eucharist!
- ◆ Sanctification comes about our desire to prepare and participate in The Divine Liturgy.
- ◆ Preparation is accomplished by fasting, praying, and striving to live an Orthodox way of life.
- ◆ Participation is our involvement in The Divine Liturgy, which culminates in the holy Eucharist.



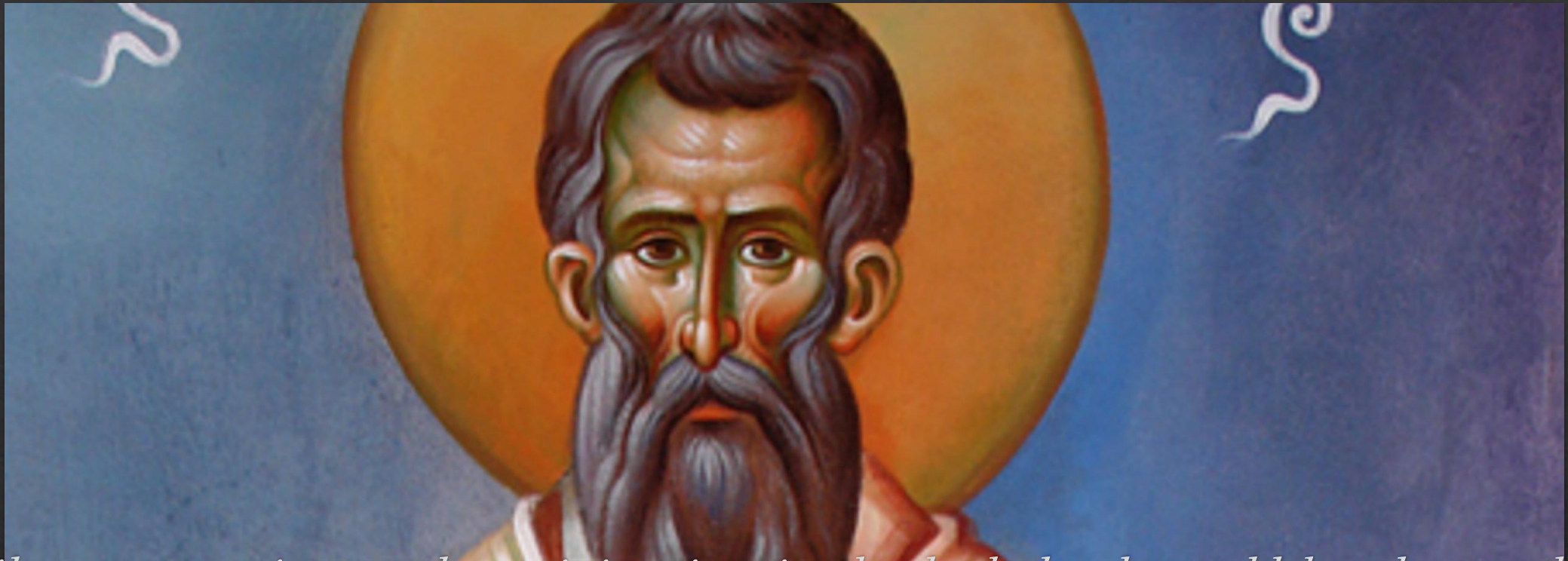


# Holy Communion from the Saints

- ❖ *“In partaking of the holy sacrament be as sure that you partake of the body and blood of Christ as you are sure that every moment you breathe air”*
- ❖ *“How can you receive the Body of Christ worthily, with faith and love, when you despise His members, or have no compassion upon them? All Christians are members of Christ, especially those that are poor. Love His members, have compassion upon them, and the Master will bestow His great mercy plentifully upon you. And can any mercy be greater than that which He bestows upon us in the communion of His Immaculate Body and Blood?”*
- ❖ St. John of Kronstadt (1829 -1909)







*“Daily communion and participation in the holy body and blood says, ‘he who eats my flesh and drinks my blood of Christ is a good and helpful practice. Christ clearly has eternal life.’ Who doubts that to partake of life continually is really to have life in abundance? For myself, I communicate four times a week... on the Lord's day, on Wednesday, on Friday, and on Saturday, and on other days if there is a commemoration of a martyr.”*

St. Basil the Great